heavier isotopes of hydrogen and used in nuclear reactors. The resulting fissile material was not placed under safeguards, but India agreed to use it for peaceful purposes. After 1960, India developed a nuclear power station at Tarapur, that would be supplied and financed with assistance from the United States. Although the financial terms for Tarapur were generous, the agreement was criticized in India for being unduly reliant on the Americans, for it required enriched uranium rather than natural uranium, on the grounds that it would produce cheaper electricity. Furthermore, the deal was criticized for being intrusive because of international safeguards, which would ensure that material was not diverted for other uses (non-US fuel used at the facility could be used for other purposes). By the late 1950s, nuclear energy accounted for over a quarter of India's research and development investment and the Atomic Energy Establishment at Trombay (later the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre or BARC) had over 1000 scientists and engineers. [55]

While publicly disavowing the possibility of using atomic energy for 'evil purposes', Nehru and Bhabha kept open the option of nuclear weapons. [56] In 1958, Bhabha built a plant, named Phoenix, to extract plutonium from spent fuel, and with CIRUS this produced India's first weapon-grade plutonium by the mid-1960s. During this period of the early Cold War, the strong international taboo against nuclear weapons that exists today was absent. Most countries that had the ability to acquire nuclear weapons did so, or at least tried to do so. Moreover, in the 1950s there was acceptability, even enthusiasm, about the use of 'peaceful nuclear explosions' (PNEs, sometimes called Plowshare devices), including for excavation, mining, and other such civilian purposes. Both the United States and the Soviet Union engaged in their development. But in reality, there was little meaningful technological difference between a PNE and an explosive device that could be weaponized and used for military purposes. [57]

As early as 1959, amid deteriorating relations with Beijing, concerns began to be raised in India about China's nuclear programme. Nehru authorized an expert group to look into a nuclear explosion in early 1962